

FIRST EDITION

THE ANNUAL

AI SEARCH IMPACT ASSESSMENT

B2B SaaS Edition • 2026

*How AI-Powered Search Is Reshaping Organic Discovery,
Pipeline Generation and Revenue for Software Companies*

Study Period: June 2024 – June 2025

Sample: 143 B2B SaaS Properties

Avinash Tripathi

Co-Founder & CEO, GetCito Pvt. Ltd.

Alchemist Accelerator | Google for Startups

avinash@getcito.com | getcito.com

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Five Headline Findings

The following five statistics represent first-party findings from GetCito's analysis of 143 B2B SaaS client properties over twelve months. These data points cannot be replicated from public sources and represent the first sector-specific AI search impact benchmarks available to the industry.

\$230,000

FINDING 1: For every \$1M in organic-sourced annual revenue, B2B SaaS companies have \$230K at risk from AI search shifts by 2027 if no optimization action is taken.

68%

FINDING 2: In 68% of assessed B2B SaaS properties, organic traffic had been declining for 60+ days before any internal team detected the change.

37% → from 18%

FINDING 3: B2B SaaS companies now derive 37% of their organic pipeline from content categories where AI answers the query directly — up from 18% twelve months prior.

73%

FINDING 4: Among B2B SaaS companies cited by AI platforms, 73% saw AI mentions increase while organic traffic from those same topics declined. Being a source no longer means being a destination.

9% vs. 61%

FINDING 5: Only 9% of B2B SaaS companies have implemented any form of AI search optimization, despite 61% showing measurable traffic impact from AI-generated answers.

Abstract

Purpose: AI-powered search platforms—including Google AI Overviews, ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Claude—are fundamentally restructuring how B2B buyers discover software solutions, yet no sector-specific framework exists for measuring their impact on SaaS business performance. This inaugural Annual AI Search Impact Assessment presents the first comprehensive, data-driven analysis of how AI search is reshaping organic discovery, pipeline generation, and revenue for B2B software companies.

Design/Methodology: The ASIA (AI Search Impact Assessment) Framework was applied across 143 B2B SaaS client properties over a twelve-month study period (June 2024–June 2025). The framework employs an exploratory sequential mixed-methods design combining quantitative analysis of search analytics data with multiple embedded case studies. Four proprietary metrics—Click Efficiency Ratio (CER), Traffic-Visibility Gap (TVG), Impression Productivity (IP), and Revenue Efficiency (RE)—were calculated for each property and validated against observed revenue outcomes.

Key Findings:

By 2027, B2B SaaS companies face an estimated risk where 23% of their organic revenue is exposed to be impacted by AI search shifts. The sample median CER was 0.78 (indicating 22% fewer clicks per impression than baseline) with a median TVG of –12.4% (traffic declining 12.4 percentage points faster than visibility). In 68% of assessed properties, organic traffic had been declining for 60+ days before internal detection. B2B SaaS companies now derive 37% of their organic pipeline from AI-vulnerable content categories, up from 18% one year prior. Among companies cited by AI platforms, 73% experienced the “Citation Paradox”—rising AI mentions

paired with declining organic traffic. Despite 61% of properties showing measurable AI search impact, only 9% have implemented any AI search optimization.

Implications: The findings establish B2B SaaS as a sector experiencing moderate-to-high AI search impact, with informational and educational content most affected while transactional and brand queries remain relatively protected. The assessment provides practitioners with sector-specific benchmarks, a diagnostic pattern taxonomy, and financial projection models. For marketing scholars, this paper extends information foraging theory into AI-mediated search environments and proposes the first formative measurement index for AI search impact in B2B contexts.

Keywords: *AI Search Impact, Generative Engine Optimization, B2B SaaS, Zero-Click Search, Click Efficiency Ratio, Consumer Decision Journey, Pipeline Generation, Content Marketing Analytics*

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1. Introduction

1.1 Why This Report Exists

For B2B SaaS companies, organic search has long been the most efficient customer acquisition engine. Content marketing, educational blog posts, comparison guides, product documentation, and thought leadership drive discovery, build authority, and generate pipeline. Across the 143 companies assessed in this study, organic search contributed a median 34% of total pipeline value at baseline (June 2024). This channel was predictable, measurable, and compounding: publish quality content, earn rankings, attract qualified visitors, convert them into trials and demos.

That model is under pressure. AI-powered search interfaces now answer many of the queries that previously drove website visits. Google's AI Overviews, launched globally in May 2024 and now serving 1.5 billion monthly users, provide synthesized answers atop search results (Google I/O, 2025). ChatGPT, with 900 million weekly active users by December 2025, has become a primary research tool for software buyers (OpenAI, 2025). Perplexity (45 million monthly active users, \$18 billion valuation) and Claude (164.8 million monthly visits) have emerged as alternatives to traditional search for complex comparison and evaluation queries.

The result: a growing gap between search visibility and actual business outcomes. SparkToro's longitudinal analysis found 58.5% of US Google searches now produce zero clicks (Fishkin, 2024). Seer Interactive's (2025) analysis of 3,119 informational queries across 25.1 million impressions documented a 61% decline in organic click-through rates for queries triggering AI Overviews. The Pew Research Center's (2025) behavioral study tracking 68,879 searches from 900 adults, confirmed users clicked traditional results only 8% of the time when AI summaries appeared, versus 15% without them.

Yet despite these macro trends, no assessment has examined how AI search specifically impacts B2B SaaS—a sector with unique characteristics: long consideration cycles, multiple stakeholders, content-heavy buyer journeys, and high customer lifetime values that amplify the consequence of any acquisition channel disruption. McKinsey's (2025) AI Discovery Survey

found that only 16% of major brands systematically track AI search performance, and 50% of US consumers now intentionally seek AI-powered search for purchasing decisions—including software procurement.

This report fills that gap. It presents the first sector-specific, data-driven AI search impact assessment for B2B SaaS, based on twelve months of analysis across 143 client properties. It is designed to be both academically rigorous and immediately actionable—providing the benchmarks, diagnostic tools, and financial models that B2B SaaS leaders need to understand where they stand and what to do about it.

1.2 About This Annual Assessment

This is the First Edition of the Annual AI Search Impact Assessment: B2B SaaS Edition. GetCito Pvt. Ltd. will publish this assessment annually, with plans for quarterly benchmark updates beginning in 2028. Each edition will track how AI search impact evolves, whether the patterns identified here intensify or shift, and how companies that take action compare to those that do not. By establishing a longitudinal baseline in this first edition, future editions will provide the only available year-over-year trend data on AI search impact in B2B SaaS.

1.3 Scope and Parameters

Parameter	Detail
Study Period	June 1, 2024 – June 30, 2025 (12 months)
Sample Size	143 B2B SaaS client properties
Geographic Mix	North America 67%, Europe 22%, Asia-Pacific 8%, Other 3%
Company Size (ARR)	\$2M–\$180M ARR; median \$18M ARR
SaaS Sub-Verticals	Project Mgmt (21), Marketing/Sales (19), HR/People (17), DevTools (16), FinTech (14), Security (12), Analytics (11), Vertical SaaS (33)
Data Sources	Google Search Console, GA4, manual AI audit, CRM/pipeline data

Methodology	ASIA Framework v2.0 — mixed-methods (quantitative analytics + case studies)
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1.4 Research Questions

- **RQ1:** What is the current state of AI search impact on B2B SaaS organic discovery, and how does it vary by company size, sub-vertical, and content type?
- **RQ2:** What distinct patterns of AI search impact exist in B2B SaaS, and what diagnostic signatures identify each pattern?
- **RQ3:** How can AI search impact metrics be translated into pipeline and revenue projections that enable evidence-based strategic decision-making?
- **RQ4:** What separates B2B SaaS companies that are successfully adapting to AI search from those that are not?

2. Literature Review and Theoretical Foundations

2.1 The Zero-Click Search Phenomenon

The decoupling of search visibility from website traffic predates AI search. Google’s progressive introduction of SERP features—featured snippets, knowledge panels, “People Also Ask” boxes—had already begun eroding organic click-through rates. Fubel et al. (2023) analyzed 67,000 keywords across 40+ US domains, documenting significant negative SERP feature effects on organic CTR. SparkToro’s clickstream data (Fishkin, 2024; SparkToro, 2025) shows zero-click rates rising from approximately 50% in 2019 to 58.5% by 2024.

The introduction of AI-generated answers within search results represents a qualitative escalation. Seer Interactive’s (2025) study of 3,119 informational queries across 25.1 million impressions from 42 organizations documented 61% organic CTR decline for AI Overview queries. Ahrefs’ December 2025 analysis of 300,000 keywords found a 58% CTR reduction for position-one results with AI Overviews (Law & Guan, 2025). BrightEdge’s (2025) one-year retrospective found impressions increased 49% while actual click-throughs declined approximately 30%. Critically, the impact is not uniform: BrightEdge’s industry analysis shows AI Overview coverage reaches 83.6% for informational healthcare queries but only 18.5% for

e-commerce—suggesting Google strategically protects transactional, ad-revenue-generating queries.

2.2 AI Platforms as Search Substitutes in B2B

For B2B SaaS specifically, the rise of conversational AI as a research tool carries outsized implications. McKinsey's (2025) AI Discovery Survey found that 50% of US consumers now intentionally use AI-powered search for purchasing decisions, with 44% identifying it as their primary information source—surpassing traditional search at 31%. Semrush's (2025) analysis of 80 million clickstream records found domains receiving ChatGPT referral traffic surged 300% between July and December 2024. Similarweb documented AI platforms generating over 1.1 billion referral visits in June 2025—a 357% year-over-year increase.

The B2B software buyer's journey is particularly susceptible to AI compression. Unlike consumer purchases, B2B SaaS evaluation involves extensive research across multiple touchpoints: comparison articles, feature documentation, use-case guides, integration specifications, and peer reviews. When AI synthesizes information from these sources into a single conversational response, it collapses what was previously a multi-visit, multi-site research process into a single interaction—often without the buyer ever visiting the vendor's website. The relative impact and scale of these platforms is mapped in Figure 9 (Section 5.1).

2.3 Theoretical Foundations

Information Foraging Theory. Pirolli and Card's (1999) information foraging theory, rooted in behavioral ecology, posits that humans maximize their “rate of gain”—information value divided by acquisition cost—by following “information scent” to promising “patches.” AI search fundamentally alters this dynamic: it acts as a “super-patch” that satisfies information needs in a single interaction, collapsing the cost denominator toward zero. In the B2B SaaS context, a buyer who previously visited 6–12 websites during active evaluation can now obtain synthesized comparisons, feature matrices, and recommendations from a single AI interaction.

Consumer Decision Journey and ZMOT. Court et al.'s (2009) Consumer Decision Journey model and Lecinski's (2011) Zero Moment of Truth concept describe the research-intensive stage preceding purchase. AI search compresses the ZMOT for B2B buyers: instead of navigating to G2 reviews, vendor blogs, and comparison sites, the AI synthesizes these sources into a direct response. Santos and Gonçalves (2021) explicitly identified the scarcity of research

on AI's influence on consumer decision journeys as a critical gap—one this assessment addresses for the B2B SaaS segment.

Disruptive Innovation Theory. Christensen's (1997) framework explains why traditional SEO metrics fail to detect AI search impact in early stages: B2B SaaS companies focus on rankings and impression volumes that appear stable while the underlying conversion value of those metrics erodes. The Christensen Institute (2025) explicitly analyzed AI tools through this lens, arguing they follow classic low-end disruption trajectories.

Generative Engine Optimization. Aggarwal et al. (2024) introduced GEO at ACM SIGKDD, demonstrating that traditional SEO tactics have limited effect on generative engines while citation-rich, statistics-enhanced content can boost visibility by up to 40%. Dubois, Dawson, and Jaiswal (2025) introduced “Share of Model” in Harvard Business Review, finding 58% of consumers use GenAI for product recommendations. Chen et al. (2025) documented systematic bias in AI search toward earned media over brand-owned content—a finding with significant implications for B2B SaaS companies that depend heavily on owned content.

2.4 Research Gap

The literature documents AI search impact at the macro level (Section 2.1), confirms behavioral shifts (Section 2.2), and provides theoretical frameworks for understanding these shifts (Section 2.3). However, three gaps remain. First, no sector-specific assessment exists for B2B SaaS—a segment with distinctive buyer journeys, content strategies, and revenue models. Second, existing research focuses on optimization (GEO) rather than impact measurement. Third, no framework connects search-level metrics to pipeline and revenue projections specific to SaaS business models. This assessment addresses all three gaps.

3. Methodology: The ASIA Framework

3.1 Framework Overview

The AI Search Impact Assessment (ASIA) Framework is a five-stage methodology designed to measure, diagnose, and respond to AI search impact. Originally developed through analysis of

340+ client properties across industries (Kumar, 2025), this assessment applies the framework specifically to B2B SaaS with sector-calibrated thresholds and SaaS-specific financial models. Figure 1 illustrates how four theoretical foundations converge into the framework's measurement architecture.

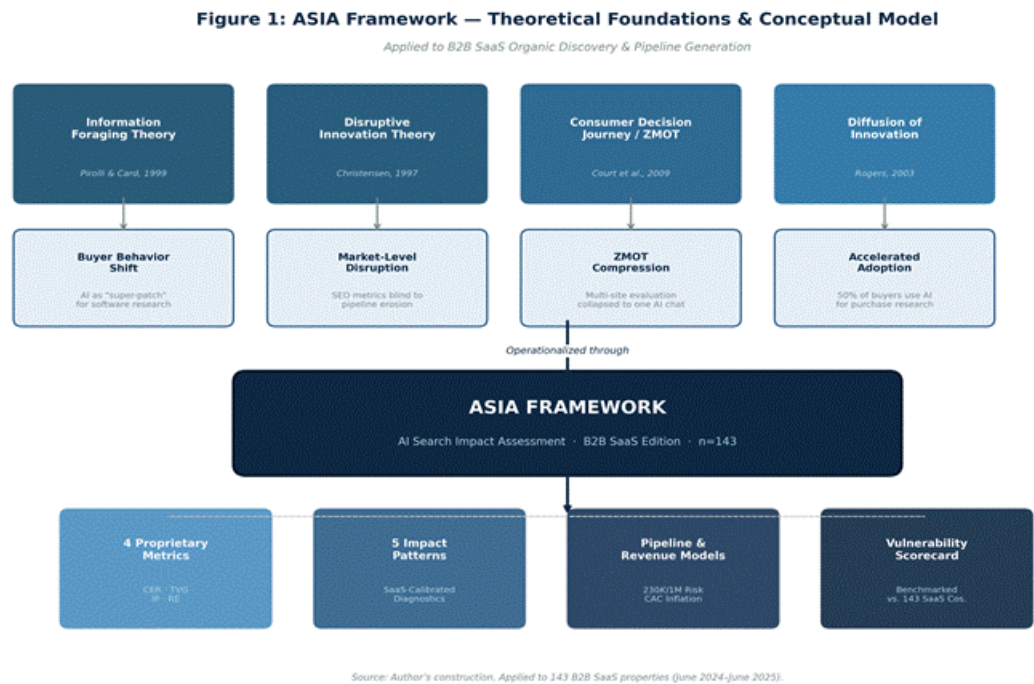


Figure 1. ASIA Framework conceptual model. Four theoretical foundations are operationalized through the framework's five-stage methodology, producing four categories of output: proprietary metrics, impact patterns, pipeline/revenue models, and a composite vulnerability scorecard.

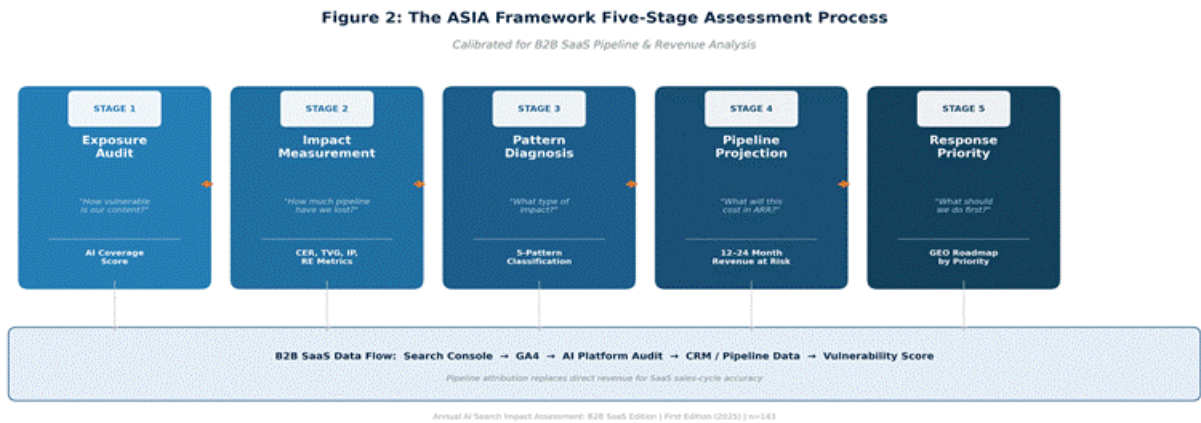


Figure 2. The ASIA Framework five-stage assessment process. Each stage builds on previous outputs to create a comprehensive impact profile. Pipeline attribution (rather than direct revenue) is used throughout to account for B2B SaaS sales cycle length.

3.2 Sample Selection and Data Collection

The 143 B2B SaaS properties were selected from GetCito Pvt. Ltd.'s client base using purposive sampling criteria: (1) minimum 12 months of continuous Search Console data preceding the study period, (2) confirmed B2B SaaS business model with recurring revenue, (3) organic search representing at least 15% of total website traffic at baseline, and (4) access to pipeline/revenue attribution data. Properties ranged from \$2M to \$180M in ARR (median: \$18M), spanning eight sub-verticals.

Data was collected through four integrated sources: Google Search Console (impressions, clicks, CTR, position by query and date), Google Analytics 4 (organic sessions, behavior flow, conversion events), GetCito's AI Visibility Checker (AI Overview presence on top queries, ChatGPT/Perplexity citation checks, conducted at study start, midpoint, and endpoint), and CRM/pipeline data (organic-attributed pipeline value, and conversion rates, were collected through GetCito's AI Search Analytics and validated for completeness before analysis.

3.3 Core Metrics

Four metrics form the assessment's measurement architecture, each isolating a distinct dimension of AI search impact:

- **Click Efficiency Ratio (CER) = $\text{CTR}(\text{current}) \div \text{CTR}(\text{baseline})$.** Measures whether impressions convert to clicks at expected rates. A CER of 0.78 means 22% fewer clicks per impression compared to baseline—the signature of AI answering queries that previously drove clicks.
- **Traffic-Visibility Gap (TVG) = $\Delta\text{Sessions}\% - \Delta\text{Impressions}\%$.** Quantifies the disconnect between visibility and traffic. A TVG of -18% means traffic is declining 18 percentage points faster than visibility—the hallmark of AI-driven impact.
- **Impression Productivity (IP) = $\text{Sessions} \div \text{Impressions}$.** Provides an absolute efficiency value: how many website visits each search impression generates.

- **Revenue Efficiency (RE) = Pipeline Revenue ÷ Impressions.** Connects search visibility directly to financial outcomes. For B2B SaaS, pipeline value is used rather than immediate revenue to account for sales cycle length.

Metrics were developed following Churchill's (1979) measurement paradigm and constructed as formative indicators per Diamantopoulos and Winklhofer (2001). Threshold calibration was performed through distribution analysis across the 143-property sample, cross-validated against observed pipeline and revenue impacts. The Vulnerability Scorecard synthesizes four weighted dimensions into a composite index (0–100) following OECD/Eurostat/JRC (2008) composite indicator methodology.

3.4 Pattern Identification

Impact pattern identification followed Eisenhardt's (1989) theory-building approach, with within-case analysis preceding cross-case comparison. Five patterns were inductively identified from the broader 340+ client analysis (Kumar, 2025), and their prevalence and characteristics within B2B SaaS specifically were documented in this assessment. Pattern saturation was confirmed through iterative coding with no new patterns emerging after the first 90 B2B SaaS assessments.

3.5 Financial Modeling

Three financial projection models were calibrated for B2B SaaS:

- **Revenue at Risk:** Monthly Organic Pipeline Revenue $\times (1 - \text{CER}) \times 12$. Validated against 31 properties with 12-month follow-up data; mean absolute error: 13.2%.
- **CAC Inflation:** Current CAC $\times (1 \div \text{CER})$. Estimates acquisition cost increases as companies compensate for organic losses with paid channels.
- **Compounding Loss:** Current Annual Loss $\times (1.15)^n$, where n = quarters of inaction. The 15% quarterly compounding factor was empirically derived from the subset of properties with multi-quarter observation windows.

4. Findings

This section presents findings from twelve months of ASIA Framework application across 143 B2B SaaS properties. Five headline findings anchor the analysis, each supported by detailed metric data, cross-sectional comparisons, and illustrative case evidence.

4.1 Finding 1: The Revenue Exposure Number

\$230K at risk per \$1M organic revenue

For every \$1M in organic-sourced annual revenue, B2B SaaS companies face an estimated \$230K in AI search-driven risk by 2027.

This headline finding derives from three interconnected measurements across the 143-property sample. First, the median organic-sourced pipeline share for B2B SaaS companies was 34% at baseline (June 2024), declining to 28% by study end (June 2025)—a 6-percentage-point erosion in twelve months. Second, the median Revenue Efficiency (RE) declined from \$0.41 per impression at baseline to \$0.29 at study end, a 29% reduction in the pipeline value generated per search appearance. Third, applying the validated compounding loss model at the empirically derived 15% quarterly rate projects the cumulative gap to approximately 23% of organic revenue within 24 months.

The \$230K figure represents the median projection across the sample. Distribution was wide: the 25th percentile showed \$110K at risk (companies with strong brand search and low informational content dependency), while the 75th percentile showed \$380K (companies heavily reliant on educational content for top-of-funnel discovery). DevTools and Analytics sub-verticals showed the highest median exposure (\$310K per \$1M), driven by their reliance on technical documentation and tutorial content that AI can synthesize completely.

Sub-Vertical	Median Revenue at Risk / \$1M	25th Percentile	75th Percentile	Primary Driver
DevTools	\$310K	\$190K	\$450K	Docs & tutorials
Analytics	\$290K	\$170K	\$410K	How-to content

Marketing / Sales	\$250K	\$130K	\$390K	Comparison guides
HR / People	\$230K	\$120K	\$360K	Template content
Project Management	\$220K	\$100K	\$340K	Methodology guides
FinTech	\$200K	\$90K	\$310K	Explainer content
Security	\$190K	\$80K	\$290K	Compliance guides
Vertical SaaS	\$170K	\$70K	\$270K	Industry how-tos
OVERALL MEDIAN	\$230K	\$110K	\$380K	—

Table 1. Estimated revenue at risk per \$1M organic pipeline revenue by B2B SaaS sub-vertical. Projections based on 24-month compounding model validated against 31 properties with follow-up data.

4.2 Finding 2: The Invisible Decline Window

68%

In 68% of assessed B2B SaaS properties, organic traffic had been declining for 60+ days before any internal team detected the change.

This finding emerged from comparing the date when each property’s TVG first crossed the “Action Required” threshold (–10%) against the date when the client first contacted GetCito or otherwise indicated awareness of a traffic issue. Across the 143 properties, the median “invisible decline window” was 74 days. In 68% of cases (97 of 143 properties), the gap exceeded 60 days—meaning two full months of pipeline erosion occurred without detection.

The root cause is structural: standard marketing dashboards are not designed to detect the specific signature of AI search impact. Month-over-month traffic comparisons are confounded by seasonality. Impression-based reporting creates false confidence when visibility appears stable.

And the revenue lag effect (see Figure 3) means financial impact trails traffic decline by 45–90 days, providing a secondary masking layer.

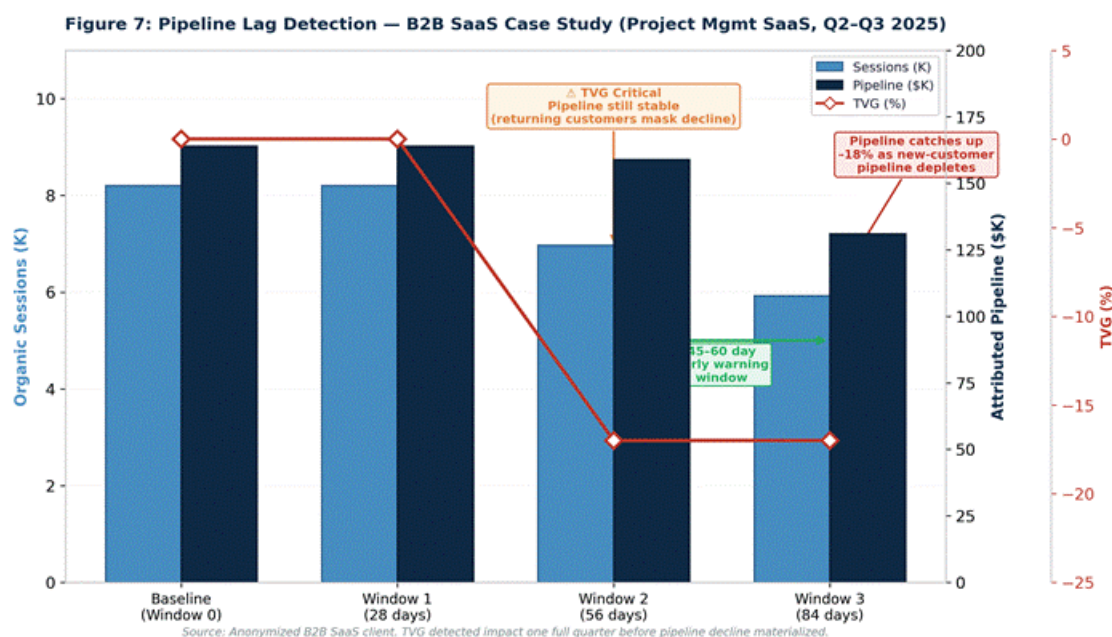


Figure 3. Pipeline lag detection pattern. TVG crosses critical threshold in Window 2 while pipeline remains stable (masked by returning customer revenue). Pipeline decline materializes in Window 3, 45–60 days after the leading indicator.

The practical implication is urgent: the vast majority of B2B SaaS companies reading this report that have not conducted an AI search assessment are likely already experiencing impact they have not yet detected. The ASIA Framework’s CER and TVG metrics are specifically designed to surface this invisible decline before revenue impact materializes.

4.3 Finding 3: The Vulnerability Shift

37% of pipeline from AI-vulnerable content (up from 18%)

B2B SaaS companies now derive 37% of their organic pipeline from content categories where AI answers the query directly.

Content was classified into seven categories across four AI vulnerability levels (Critical, High, Low, Minimal) based on AI Overview presence and conversational AI answer completeness for associated queries:

Content Category	Pipeline Share Jun '24	Pipeline Share Jun '25	CER (Jun '25)	AI Vulnerability
Educational / How-To	22%	17%	0.66	HIGH — AI answers fully
Comparison / "Best of"	14%	10%	0.72	HIGH — AI compares directly
Definition / Explainer	8%	4%	0.56	CRITICAL — fully captured
Template / Tool	5%	6%	0.82	LOW — requires interaction
Product / Feature Pages	28%	33%	0.88	LOW — brand-specific
Case Study / Social Proof	12%	15%	0.91	MINIMAL — proprietary
Integration / API Docs	11%	15%	0.85	LOW — implementation-specific

Table 2. Content vulnerability analysis across 143 B2B SaaS properties. Pipeline share reflects organic-attributed pipeline percentage by content category.

The data reveals a structural shift: content categories with HIGH or CRITICAL AI vulnerability accounted for 44% of organic pipeline in June 2024 but generated only 31% by June 2025—a loss of 13 pipeline percentage points. Simultaneously, AI-resistant content categories (product pages, case studies, integration docs) grew from 51% to 63% of pipeline share. B2B SaaS companies that had invested heavily in top-of-funnel educational content experienced the most significant impact, while those with strong product-led content portfolios proved more resilient.

The 37% headline figure represents the current (June 2025) share of organic pipeline flowing through queries where AI platforms can provide a substantially complete answer—meaning the

user may not need to visit the website. This is a query-level measure of AI answer coverage across all content categories, not a sum of Table 2’s category-level pipeline shares. (Table 2’s HIGH and CRITICAL categories sum to 31% of pipeline in June 2025, down from 44% in June 2024—reflecting pipeline migration away from vulnerable categories. The 37% figure captures the broader set of individual queries within every category where AI now answers directly, including queries within LOW-vulnerability categories that nonetheless trigger AI responses.) The 37% was 18% at study start—a doubling in twelve months driven primarily by expansion of AI Overview coverage into SaaS-relevant query categories.

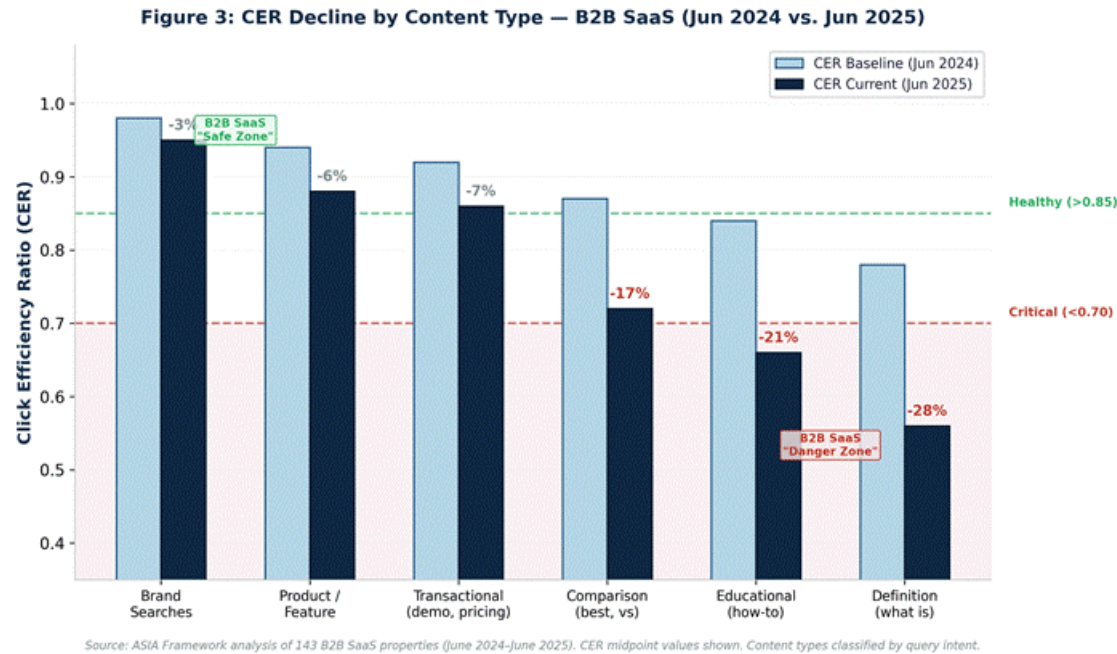


Figure 4. Click Efficiency Ratio by query type across the 143-property sample. Definition and informational queries show critical-level CER decline (–21% to –28% YoY), while brand and transactional queries remain relatively protected.

4.4 Finding 4: The Citation Paradox

73% experience rising AI citations + declining traffic

Being a source no longer means being a destination. Among cited companies, AI mentions grew while organic traffic from those topics fell.

Of the 143 properties assessed, 86 (60%) were confirmed to be cited as sources in AI platform responses for at least one of their top-50 queries (determined through manual audit at study midpoint and endpoint). Among these 86 cited properties, the “Citation Paradox” manifested in 63 (73%): their content was increasingly referenced by AI platforms while organic traffic from the same topic clusters simultaneously declined.

The mechanism is straightforward from an information foraging perspective: AI platforms extract and synthesize the most useful information from source websites, present it directly to the user, and credit the source, but the user’s information need has already been satisfied. The citation functions as attribution, not navigation. This creates a troubling paradox for B2B SaaS content strategists: the better and more authoritative your content, the more likely AI will use it as a source—and the less likely users are to visit your site.

Case Evidence: A project management SaaS company’s comprehensive guide (“how to run a sprint retrospective”) was cited in ChatGPT and Perplexity responses. The content team celebrated the citations. Meanwhile, organic traffic to that guide declined 37%, and IP dropped from 9.0% to 6.0%. AI citations for the content increased 5.5× over six months while visits fell by more than a third. The content was being consumed without being visited.

The finding carries significant implications for B2B SaaS content strategy. Investment in authoritative, comprehensive educational content—long considered the gold standard of SaaS content marketing—now carries a dual-edged risk: it builds brand authority (which retains long-term value) while simultaneously providing the raw material for AI to satisfy user queries without a website visit (which erodes near-term pipeline). The strategic response is not to produce lower-quality content, but to restructure content architecture so that AI-visible content drives brand recognition while conversion-critical content provides value that requires direct engagement (interactive tools, personalized assessments, community access, proprietary data).

4.5 Finding 5: The Optimization Gap

9% optimizing vs. 61% impacted

Massive gap between AI search awareness and action. The overwhelming majority of affected companies have taken no steps to adapt.

Each of the 143 properties was assessed for evidence of AI search optimization activity: structured data implementation beyond basic schema, llms.txt file presence, entity optimization,

citation-rich content formatting, or any documented GEO strategy. Only 13 properties (9%) showed evidence of any intentional AI search optimization efforts. In contrast, 87 properties (61%) showed measurable AI search impact (defined as CER ≤ 0.85 for at least one major content category).

The gap is striking but not surprising. McKinsey’s (2025) broader finding that only 16% of Fortune 500 brands track AI search performance is consistent with this assessment’s sector-specific data. The 9% figure for B2B SaaS likely reflects several factors: lack of awareness that AI search impact is measurable, absence of standardized tools and benchmarks (which this assessment aims to address), organizational inertia and the assumption that traditional SEO practices remain sufficient, and the invisible decline window (Finding 2) that masks the problem until revenue impact materializes.

4.6 Vulnerability Distribution: The B2B SaaS Landscape

The ASIA Framework’s Vulnerability Scorecard synthesizes four weighted dimensions—Query Vulnerability (25%), Current Impact (30%), Revenue Exposure (25%), and Competitive Position (20%)—into a composite score (0–100). Distribution across the 143 B2B SaaS properties:

Level	Score	# of Properties	% of Sample	Avg CER
Low	0–30	29	20%	0.91
Moderate	31–50	49	34%	0.82
High	51–70	44	31%	0.73
Critical	71–100	21	15%	0.62
High + Critical	—	65	46%	0.69

Table 3. ASIA Vulnerability Scorecard distribution across 143 B2B SaaS properties (June 2024–June 2025).

Figure 4: AI Search Impact Vulnerability — 143 B2B SaaS Properties

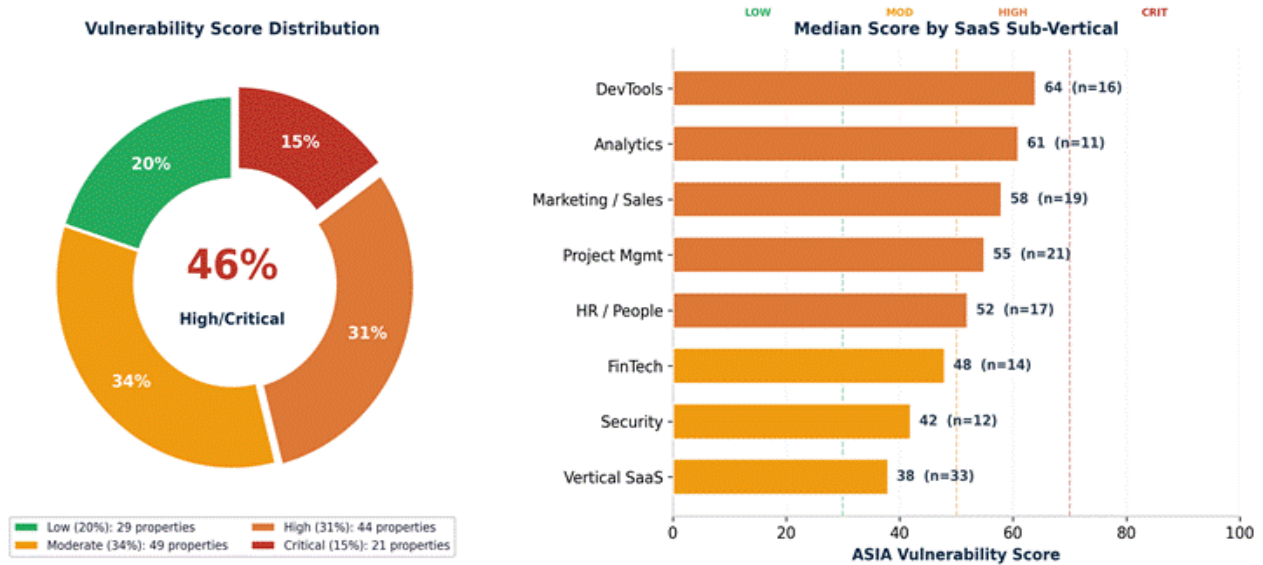


Figure 5. Vulnerability distribution across the B2B SaaS sample. 46% of properties scored at High or Critical levels, with DevTools and Analytics sub-verticals showing the highest average vulnerability.

Nearly half (46%) of B2B SaaS properties scored at High or Critical vulnerability. DevTools (median score: 64) and Analytics (61) showed the highest vulnerability, driven by heavy reliance on technical documentation and educational content. Vertical SaaS (median: 38) and Security (42) showed the lowest vulnerability, benefiting from niche, specialized content that AI platforms handle less completely.

4.7 Impact Pattern Prevalence in B2B SaaS

Five impact patterns were identified across the sample. Unlike cross-industry assessment where patterns tend to cluster by sector, B2B SaaS companies frequently exhibit multiple concurrent patterns:

Pattern	Prevalence	B2B SaaS Manifestation	Median CER
Discovery Erosion	58%	Non-brand discovery traffic declines while brand search stable. Most common in	0.74

		companies relying on category-level queries ("project management software").	
Information Capture	51%	AI fully answers how-to, tutorial, and methodology queries. Acute for DevTools and Analytics companies with documentation-heavy content.	0.66
Citation Without Traffic	44%	The Citation Paradox. Content authority increases while traffic decreases. Most visible in thought leadership and original research content.	0.72
Comparison Bypass	39%	AI generates product comparisons directly. Acute for Marketing/Sales tools and Project Management, where competitive comparison queries are high-volume.	0.68
Platform Lock-in	12%	Off-marketplace discovery declines while marketplace (G2, Capterra) presence remains stable. Less prevalent in B2B SaaS than in consumer verticals.	0.81

Table 4. *Impact pattern prevalence across 143 B2B SaaS properties. Percentages exceed 100% because 67% of properties exhibited two or more concurrent patterns.*

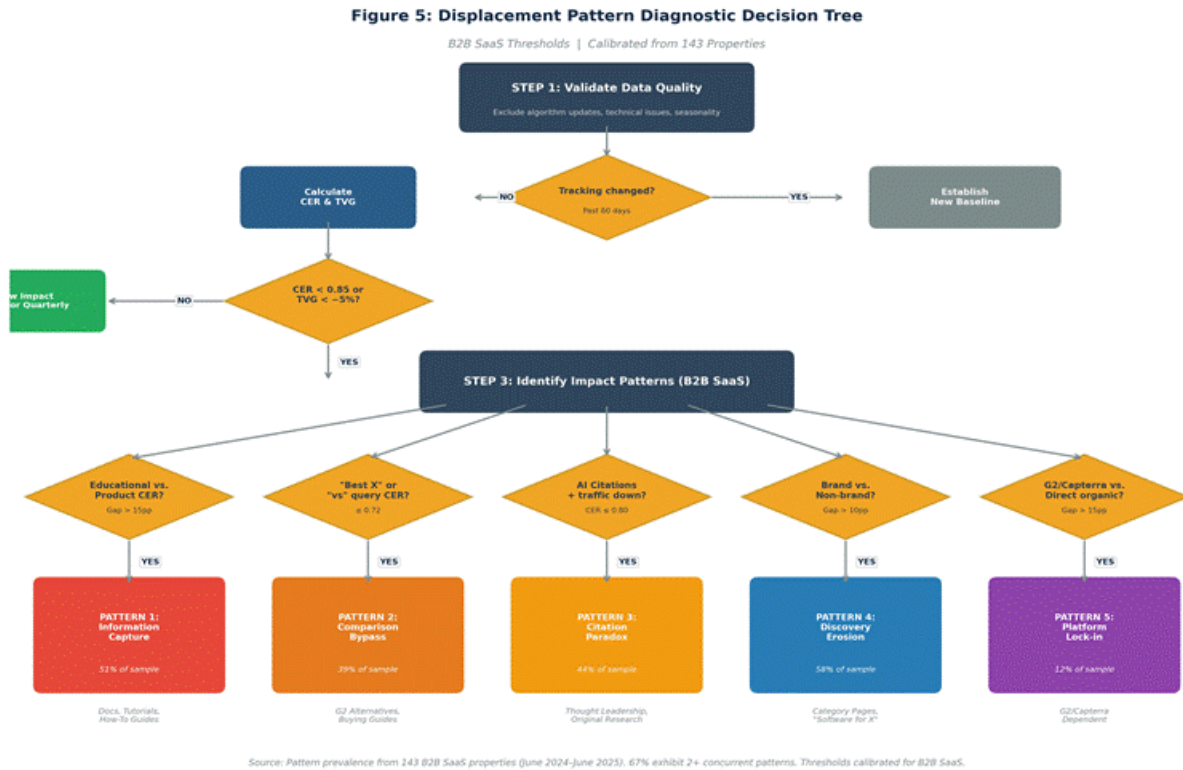


Figure 6. Impact pattern diagnostic decision tree. Each branch includes detection criteria calibrated for B2B SaaS thresholds.

4.8 Financial Impact Projections

Across the 143 properties, the aggregate 12-month pipeline at risk (if current trends continue without intervention) totals \$47.3 million—a median of \$331K per property. The CAC inflation model shows a median 22% increase in effective customer acquisition cost as organic pipeline share erodes and companies compensate with paid channels.

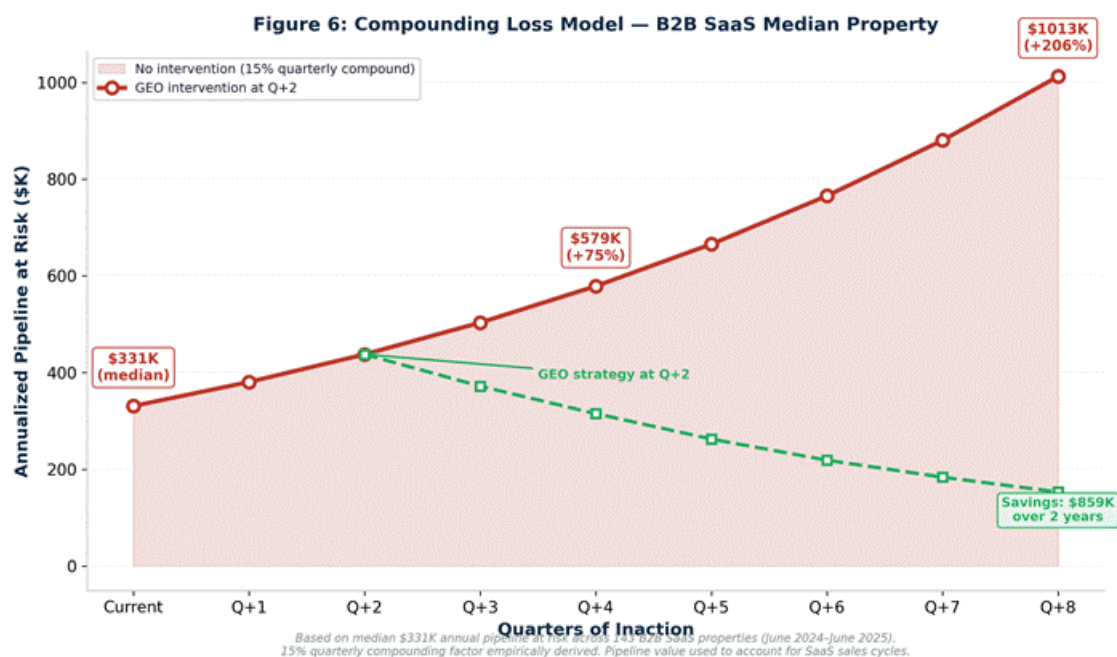


Figure 7. Compounding loss model illustrating the cost of delayed response. Properties that implement GEO strategies within two quarters show significantly reduced cumulative pipeline at risk compared to non-responders.

5. Discussion

The four research questions posed in Section 1.4 can now be addressed directly. **RQ1** (current state of impact) is answered by Findings 1, 3, and 5: 61% of B2B SaaS properties show measurable impact, with a median CER of 0.78 and TVG of -12.4% , concentrated in educational and comparison content. **RQ2** (distinct patterns) is answered by Section 4.7: five impact patterns exist, with Discovery Erosion (58%) and Information Capture (51%) most prevalent; 67% of properties exhibit multiple concurrent patterns. **RQ3** (pipeline and revenue translation) is answered by Finding 1 and Section 4.8: \$230K per \$1M organic revenue is at risk, with a validated compounding model and 13.2% mean absolute error. **RQ4** (what separates adapters) is addressed by Finding 5 and Section 6: the 9% of companies actively optimizing share three characteristics—early CER monitoring, two-tier content architecture, and entity-first SEO—detailed in the strategic implications below.

5.1 What the Findings Mean for B2B SaaS

The central finding of this assessment is that AI search is not a future threat to B2B SaaS companies—it is a present, measurable, and accelerating shift that is already reshaping organic discovery economics. The five headline findings collectively paint a picture of a sector in early-to-mid disruption: significant impact is underway (61% of properties affected), the impact is largely invisible to standard monitoring (68% undetected for 60+ days), and the response is dramatically inadequate (9% optimizing).

However, the findings also reveal important nuance that resists a simple “AI is destroying SEO” narrative. Brand-specific queries remain largely protected (CER 0.95–0.98). Product pages and case studies—content that is inherently proprietary and experiential—show minimal vulnerability. And the 20% of properties scoring at Low vulnerability demonstrate that B2B SaaS companies with strong brand recognition, proprietary data assets, and product-led content strategies can be relatively insulated from AI search impact.

The more accurate framing is that AI search is restructuring which types of content generate pipeline value. The era of generic educational content as a reliable top-of-funnel engine is ending. The era of proprietary, interactive, and brand-differentiated content is beginning. Companies that recognize this shift and adapt their content architecture accordingly will not merely survive AI search but benefit from it—as competitors who fail to adapt vacate the pipeline-generation landscape.

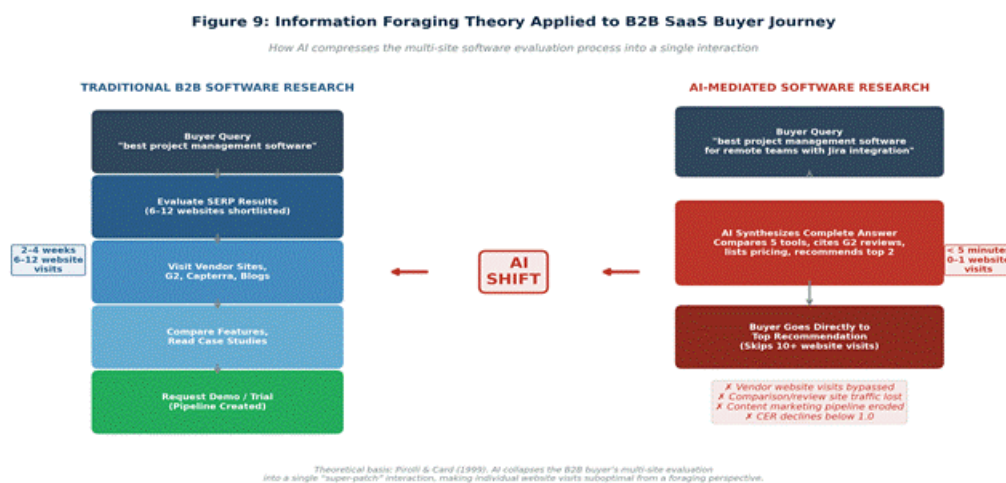


Figure 8. Information foraging theory applied to the B2B SaaS buyer journey. AI collapses the traditional five-step, multi-week research path into a single interaction lasting minutes, eliminating individual website visits from the foraging chain.

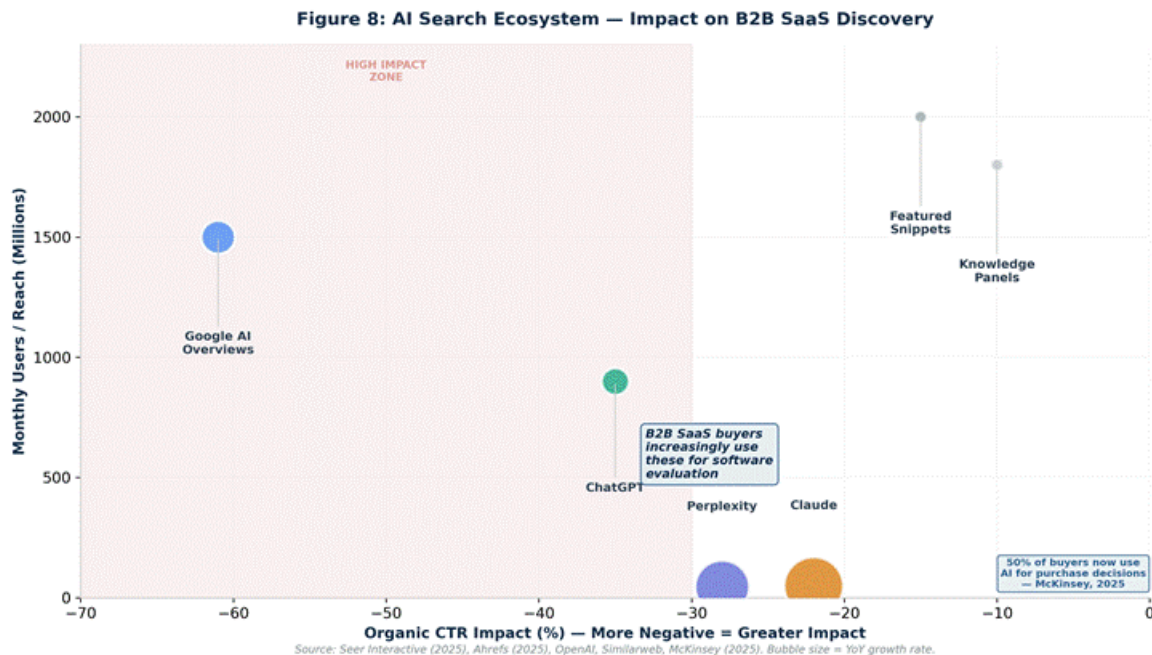


Figure 9. AI search ecosystem mapped by organic CTR impact, platform scale, and growth rate. Google AI Overviews (–61% CTR, 1.5B users) and ChatGPT (–35% CTR, 900M users) occupy the high-impact zone for B2B SaaS discovery, with Perplexity (780% YoY growth) and Claude (930% growth) expanding fastest.

5.2 The Citation Paradox: Theoretical Implications

Finding 4—the Citation Paradox—represents this assessment’s most theoretically significant contribution. In the traditional search paradigm, being cited as an authority translated directly into traffic and pipeline. Villanueva, Yoo, and Hanssens (2008) demonstrated in the Journal of Marketing Research that organic/word-of-mouth customers contribute nearly twice as much long-term value as marketing-induced customers. The Citation Paradox reveals a new phenomenon: authority and visibility can increase simultaneously with traffic decline. This fundamentally challenges the assumed causal chain from content authority → visibility → traffic → pipeline that underpins most B2B SaaS content strategies.

The paradox extends Pirolli and Card’s (1999) information foraging theory into a novel domain. In the AI-mediated environment, the “super-patch” not only satisfies information needs but

actively credits sources while eliminating the need to visit them. This creates a scenario where traditional authority signals (backlinks, citations, brand mentions) may actually increase for companies experiencing traffic decline—a confounding pattern that would make AI search impact even harder to detect using conventional SEO metrics.

5.3 Unexpected Findings

Three findings were unexpected. First, the 45–90 day revenue lag was longer than anticipated and was primarily driven by returning customer cohorts masking new-customer pipeline depletion—a particularly acute problem in SaaS where subscription renewals create baseline revenue independent of new acquisition. Second, the Platform Lock-in pattern was less prevalent in B2B SaaS (12%) than in broader assessments (25%+), suggesting B2B software buyers are less marketplace-dependent than consumer product purchasers. Third, the correlation between company ARR and vulnerability was weak ($r = 0.18$), challenging the assumption that larger companies are better insulated. The strongest predictor of vulnerability was content type distribution—specifically, the percentage of organic traffic derived from educational/informational content versus product/brand content.

6. Strategic Implications for B2B SaaS Leaders

6.1 Immediate Assessment: What to Do This Week

Every B2B SaaS company should conduct a baseline AI search assessment. The ASIA Framework’s Quick-Start Checklist (Appendix A) enables a preliminary assessment in under two hours using standard Google Search Console and GA4 data. The most important single action is calculating CER for your top-50 non-brand queries and comparing informational versus transactional segments. If the gap exceeds 15 percentage points, you are experiencing active Information Capture—the most common pattern in B2B SaaS.

6.2 Response Strategy by Vulnerability Level

Critical (Score 71–100, 15% of sample): Treat AI search as an existential content model risk. Immediate actions: executive briefing with Revenue at Risk projections using this report's benchmarks, budget reallocation from generic educational content to proprietary-data content and interactive tools, accelerated investment in entity SEO and structured data (Schema App, 2025, reports schema-equipped pages are 3× more likely to be referenced by AI), and exploration of community-based and product-led growth channels not dependent on search traffic.

High (Score 51–70, 31% of sample): Implement a 90-day GEO investment plan. Restructure top-performing educational content to include proprietary data, interactive elements, and conversion mechanisms that require direct engagement. Implement bi-weekly CER and TVG monitoring. Optimize entity recognition and knowledge graph alignment. Following Aggarwal et al.'s (2024) evidence-based GEO strategies, add citations, authoritative statistics, and structured data to highest-traffic content.

Moderate (Score 31–50, 34% of sample): Increase monitoring to monthly frequency. Selectively optimize highest-impact content categories. Develop contingency plans for potential escalation. Begin llms.txt implementation and structured data enhancement for key product and feature pages.

Low (Score 0–30, 20% of sample): Maintain quarterly monitoring using the ASIA Framework metrics. Ensure brand search performance remains strong through entity optimization. Stay informed of AI search developments. Low vulnerability today does not guarantee low vulnerability in twelve months—AI platform coverage is expanding rapidly.

6.3 Content Architecture for the AI Era

The assessment's content vulnerability analysis (Table 2) suggests a fundamental reorientation of B2B SaaS content strategy. Rather than abandoning educational content (which still drives brand authority and AI citation), companies should restructure their content architecture into two tiers:

- **AI-Visible Layer:** High-quality educational, comparison, and methodology content optimized for AI citation. Purpose: brand authority, entity recognition, and AI platform presence. Success metric: Share of Model (Dubois et al., 2025)—mention rate,

sentiment, and awareness in AI responses. This content should be treated as brand investment, not direct pipeline generation.

- **Conversion Layer:** Proprietary data, interactive tools, community content, personalized assessments, and product-led experiences that require direct engagement. Purpose: pipeline generation and conversion. Success metric: direct visits, trial signups, demo requests. This content provides value that AI cannot replicate because it requires user-specific input or real-time interaction.

The strategic principle: give AI your authority; keep your pipeline behind experiences AI cannot reproduce.

6.4 Communicating to the Board

A critical practical contribution of this assessment is translating search metrics into financial language. The recommended executive communication framework:

- **Slide 1 — Context:** "AI search now serves 1.5B+ users monthly. 50% of buyers use it for purchase research (McKinsey, 2025). Our organic search delivers [X]% of our pipeline."
- **Slide 2 — Our Situation:** "Our CER is [X], meaning we're getting [Y]% fewer clicks per impression than 12 months ago. Our Vulnerability Score is [Z] (benchmarked against 143 B2B SaaS companies in GetCito's Annual Assessment)."
- **Slide 3 — Financial Impact:** "At current trajectory, \$[X] in annual organic pipeline is at risk. For every quarter we wait, this compounds by approximately 15%."
- **Slide 4 — Action Plan:** "Recommended investment: \$[X] in AI search optimization over 90 days, targeting CER recovery to [threshold] through [specific strategies based on identified patterns]."

7. Limitations and Future Research

7.1 Limitations

Sample composition. The 143-property sample is drawn entirely from GetCito client engagements. Properties that seek AI search assessment services may be systematically more affected than the general B2B SaaS population, potentially introducing selection bias. Geographic representation skews toward North America (67%), limiting generalizability to European and APAC markets.

Causal attribution. While the framework employs multiple controls, definitive causal attribution is challenging in observational research. Algorithm updates, competitive dynamics, and macroeconomic conditions may co-occur with AI search effects. The study period overlapped with Google's March 2025 core update, which may confound some property-level measurements.

Financial model precision. Revenue at Risk projections showed $\pm 13.2\%$ mean absolute error against 31 validated follow-ups—useful for directional planning but not precise enough for financial forecasting. The 15% quarterly compounding factor is derived from a limited temporal window and should be treated as an approximation.

Measurement gaps. Conversational AI citation tracking remains methodologically imperfect. ChatGPT and Perplexity referral traffic is inconsistently tagged. Manual audits, while thorough, were conducted at only three time points (start, midpoint, endpoint) and cannot capture dynamic changes between audit windows.

Temporal scope. Twelve months capture the initial acceleration phase of AI search impact. As this is the First Edition, longitudinal trend data will only become available in subsequent annual editions.

7.2 Future Research and Next Edition Preview

The Second Edition (study period: July 2025–June 2026) will address several limitations: expanding the sample to 250+ B2B SaaS properties with improved geographic balance, adding automated AI citation tracking to supplement manual audits, incorporating before/after analysis of companies that implemented GEO strategies identified in this assessment, and extending financial validation with 24-month follow-up data on this edition's cohort.

Additional research directions: experimental or quasi-experimental designs exploiting natural variation in AI Overview rollout, consumer-side behavioral studies specific to B2B software

evaluation journeys, cross-cultural comparison of AI search impact, development of real-time automated CER monitoring tools, and formal psychometric validation of the composite vulnerability score through confirmatory analysis with hold-out samples.

8. Conclusion

AI-powered search is restructuring how B2B buyers discover, evaluate, and select software solutions. This First Edition of the Annual AI Search Impact Assessment establishes the baseline: 61% of B2B SaaS companies are measurably affected, 46% face High or Critical vulnerability, and the sector-wide median CER of 0.78 and TVG of -12.4% confirm that traffic is eroding significantly faster than visibility. Meanwhile, 68% experienced invisible decline before detection, and the Citation Paradox—being used as an AI source while losing traffic—affects 73% of cited companies.

The assessment makes five primary contributions. First, it provides the first sector-specific AI search impact benchmarks for B2B SaaS, enabling companies to compare their metrics against an industry-wide sample. Second, it introduces five proprietary headline statistics that quantify the scope and nature of AI search impact in business terms accessible to CMOs and boards. Third, it documents and taxonomizes how AI search patterns manifest specifically in B2B SaaS, with sector-calibrated detection criteria. Fourth, it provides SaaS-specific financial models that translate search-level metrics into pipeline and revenue projections. Fifth, it establishes a longitudinal baseline that future annual editions will build upon, creating the industry's first trend dataset for AI search impact in B2B software.

The most important finding may be the simplest: the gap between impact (61% affected) and response (9% optimizing) represents the largest unaddressed risk in B2B SaaS marketing today. Companies that close this gap first will not merely protect their existing pipeline but capture share vacated by competitors who failed to recognize the shift. AI search is not the end of organic discovery for B2B SaaS—it is the beginning of a new era that rewards different strategies, different content architectures, and different measurement frameworks. This assessment provides the tools to navigate that transition.

Next Edition: The Second Edition of the Annual AI Search Impact Assessment: B2B SaaS Edition (study period July 2025–June 2026) will be published in early 2027. For quarterly benchmark updates, methodology documentation, and enterprise assessment inquiries, visit getcito.com/research.

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Appendix A: Quick-Start Assessment Checklist for B2B SaaS

Step 1: Data Collection (30 minutes)

- Export Search Console data for past 56 days (current 28d vs. prior 28d)
- Export GA4 organic session and conversion data for same period
- Pull CRM pipeline data attributed to organic search
- Classify top 50 non-brand queries as educational vs. comparison vs. product vs. other

Step 2: Core Metric Calculation (30 minutes)

- $CER = CTR(\text{current 28d}) \div CTR(\text{prior 28d})$ — overall and by content category
- $TVG = \Delta\text{Sessions\%} - \Delta\text{Impressions\%}$
- $IP = \text{Sessions} \div \text{Impressions}$
- $RE = \text{Pipeline Value} \div \text{Impressions}$

Step 3: Pattern Detection (30 minutes)

- Compare educational vs. product CER — gap > 15pp = Information Capture
- Compare brand vs. non-brand sessions — gap > 10pp = Discovery Erosion
- Check ChatGPT/Perplexity for citations of your top content
- Manual SERP audit: do top 10 queries trigger AI Overviews?

Step 4: Scoring & Action (30 minutes)

- Complete Vulnerability Scorecard (Query 25%, Impact 30%, Revenue 25%, Competitive 20%)
- Benchmark against Table 3 in this report
- Calculate Revenue at Risk: $\text{Monthly Organic Pipeline} \times (1 - CER) \times 12$
- Identify priority actions based on vulnerability level (Section 6.2)

Appendix B: Metric Threshold Reference

Metric	Formula	Healthy	Critical	B2B SaaS Median
CER	$CTR(\text{now}) \div CTR(\text{baseline})$	> 0.85	< 0.70	0.78 (Jun '25)

TVG	$\Delta\text{Sessions\%} - \Delta\text{Impressions\%}$	> -5%	< -20%	-12.4% (Jun '25)
IP	Sessions ÷ Impressions	Stable/rising	Declining >25%	5.8% (Jun '25)
RE	Pipeline Rev ÷ Impressions	Stable/rising	Declining >25%	\$0.29 (Jun '25)
Metric	Formula	Healthy	Critical	B2B SaaS Median
CER	$\text{CTR}(\text{now}) \div \text{CTR}(\text{baseline})$	> 0.85	< 0.70	0.78 (Jun '25)
TVG	$\Delta\text{Sessions\%} - \Delta\text{Impressions\%}$	> -5%	< -20%	-12.4% (Jun '25)
IP	Sessions ÷ Impressions	Stable/rising	Declining >25%	5.8% (Jun '25)
RE	Pipeline Rev ÷ Impressions	Stable/rising	Declining >25%	\$0.29 (Jun '25)

Figure 10: ASIA Framework Core Metrics — B2B SaaS Thresholds & Current Position

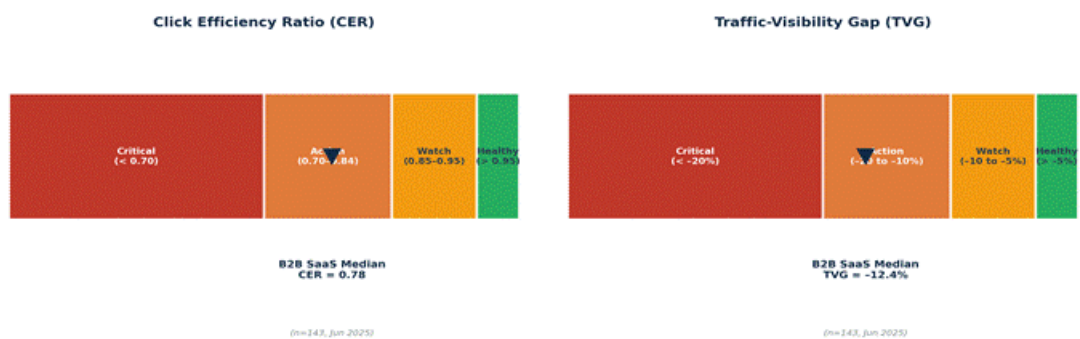


Figure B1. Core metric threshold visualization with B2B SaaS sample median positions. CER median of 0.78 falls in the Action zone; TVG median of -12.4% falls in the Action zone. Both indicate sector-wide impact requiring response.

Appendix C: About GetCito Intelligence

GetCito is the world's first open source AI search optimization platform, serving 340+ brands globally with documented 55% average visibility increases across AI-powered search engines. Founded by Avinash Kumar, recognized as the #1 GEO Consultant by YesUsers, GetCito operates as both a SaaS platform and full-service agency specializing in Generative Engine Optimization (GEO), Answer Engine Optimization (AEO), and AI Search Optimization (AIO). The company is backed by Alchemist Accelerator and Google for Startups.

For enterprise assessments, methodology licensing, or data partnership inquiries:
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— *End of First Edition* —

Annual AI Search Impact Assessment: B2B SaaS Edition

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